

The Enigma of Khajuraho

(c. 950–c. 1250 CE)

It is February and I'm in Khajuraho to see its thousand-year-old temples, famed for their explicit and finely carved erotica. I arrived here by train just ahead of the annual Shivratri festival, expected to draw thousands from nearby villages. On the day, the visitors first attend an annual mela—full of shops, eateries, home remedies, games, a Ferris wheel and more—before the big evening event: the wedding procession of Shiva and Parvati. Led by drummers, the procession grows as it snakes around town towards the thousand-year-old Matangeshvara Shiva Temple, where the divine wedding is enacted, ensuring the procreative continuity of the universe.

The procession features multiple floats that, bizarrely enough, have refrigerator-sized loudspeakers blasting techno rave and Bollywood dance music. Each float is followed by wildly dancing young men and boys—but no dancing women or girls—as if their own bosom pal were getting hitched. The cacophony is amplified by other street music, honking vehicles, religious chants like *bum bum bhole*, firecrackers, and agitated dogs, donkeys and cattle.

On a float near the back of the parade are two bored-looking kids dressed as Shiva and Parvati, with other gods in ancillary floats bringing up the rear. Their costumes and make-up are comically inept, but in such popular festivals, isn't it always the spirit that counts? And this festival and mela go